

Messages to my Children

Tyra Soosay

Viewers Page

The essay in accompaniment to the paper has a section called Appendix A. This appendix is paying honor to Aboriginal Law, and other colonial common law doctrines (such as doctrine of discovery and terra nullius) that are used to reflect where “treaty rights” and “title” come from. This appendix is my own modern twist on the way that Indigenous people are discussed (and thought of) historically today. This type of knowledge does not convey the beauty of my people. This was specifically an appendix because it is not the primary knowledge of Indigenous people, and it must come secondary to our ancestral knowledge because it does not represent who we are as a people. Appendix A’s, ways of knowing, were not included in the paper because I think it is more important that Indigenous babies know who they are from their ancestor’s eyes and where they fit into the world (not from a colonizers view). Here is what I would rather my children know about who they are;

- The paintings background is red to represent Indigenous peoples color in the medicine wheel. We are the red nation, and Creator gave us a gift before we came to the Earth, and that gift is that we are spiritual people.
- The black border around the painting represents the galaxies that surround us and is filled with stars because we are Star People. Within the galaxy there are star people and spiritual beings. These beings are within the Sundance lodge (located at the bottom of the rainbow). These spirits are spiritual beings who give us true connection, so that we can access our ancestral knowledge and be reminded of who we are and what we are meant to

become in this world. We are all spiritual beings having a spiritual experience, and the more connected to Creator we are the better protected we become by her helpers in these lodges.

- There is a star directly north of the Sundance lodge that is gold, and this star represents Star Woman. She is connected and sitting closely to Grandmother Spider. Grandmother Spider has both a connection to the galaxies and a connection to the womb. She is sitting in between both worlds. Inside the womb that Grandmother Spider is connected to, is a flame of fire that represents the spirits of our beautiful children who are sitting with Creator. Creator sits with children before they exist their mother's womb, and this is why children are the most spiritual human beings on Earth. They are the closest to the Creator.
- The womb is surrounded by mama's spirit colors (the colors of the rainbow) and represent the protection and spiritual action of becoming one with your baby. Pregnancy is a ceremony. The rainbow is a symbol of spiritual life essence and spiritual action of creating life.
- Around the painting is the sun, moon, and elements of earth. There is an Eagle feather with a baby Eagle feather plume, representing babies Anishinaabe grandmother (Changing Feather Rock). There is corn and a Blackfoot design (symbol). Overtime more Blackfoot, Cree, Anishinaabe, and Dene designs will be added to convey the beauty of our baby's ancestral beauty.

You are unconditionally loved. I am your mother, in Anishinaabe my spirit name sounds like "Aki ka pay mooh sah dang" The One Who Walks the Earth, and you will hear people call me Tyra Soosay. My colours are of the rainbow. Your father's spirit name is Cree and sounds

like “Obi wan knock mow” Whirlwind Blizzard (later Blizzard King), and you will hear people call him Jonas Soosay. We are of four Indigenous nations in addition to being husband and wife, and we are here when you need help forever and always. Your mother is Anishinaabe from your Grandmother (who is from Sagamock/Whitesands in Ontario where your family from your Grandmother/Great Grandmother are Bear Clan, Mermaid Clan, and your Great Grandfather is Thunderbird and Eagle Clan) and from your grandfather you are Sahtu Dene (from Deline, Northwest Territories, Caribou Clan). Our Dene ancestry goes back a known span of 4 generations: Doug Dillion, Elsie Madeleine (Jimmy Dillion), Alexis (Christine Dolphus), and Henri Takazo (Lucie Tsoukon). Our Dene bloodline is strong, your spiritual strength comes from your ancestry. Don’t forget to feast your ancestors and spirit helpers. Your father is Blackfoot from your Grandmother (she is from the Pikani Nation between Brocket-Alberta and Montana USA), and Cree from your Grandfather (whose territories exist on what is now known as Onion Lake First Nation, on the Saskatchewan-Alberta border, in addition to Metis ancestry). Your Blackfoot Great-Grandmother, Mrs. Man Who Smokes (Peigan) wore the headdress Sundance (Natoas) bundle. Your family are Sundance people, your family are pipe carriers, your family are sweat lodge carriers, your family will show you the methodologies and way of knowing that makes us whole as Indigenous people. We are your teachers, but we don’t own you, because you are your own spirit. The only thing you own in this world is your body, it is the physical shell you were given by the Creator. In Sundance you can pierce and give flesh offerings, because this is the only things on Earth that you can sacrifice to be bonded to the spirit world. We have existed on this Earth called Turtle Island since time immemorial. Like your ancestors you will form a bond to Creator, and hold sacred knowledge of your own that is unique to you and the Great Spirit.

Before you came to us

We have always been star people.¹ You sat with Creator before you came to us. When you sat with Creator, the spirit flame within yourself was shown to you, given to you, and you seen your life and purpose while on Earth. Before you came to us, from miracle and prayer, from deep wishes of happiness and love, we wanted you so much. You come from the stars and are apart of the gravitational pull of kinship, you are the spirit and energy of life created for us to love. Anishinaabe (and Indigenous) peoples creations stories centre at times around Clan systems. When our people came from the stars, they were given allele's that are specific to our genome system in the universe. Grandmother Spider allowed you to come through the hole in the sky guarding the milky way, to be here with your family on this Earth. Just like Star Woman, Grandmother spider lowered you through the hole in the sky, to become a visitor here on Earth. Peter O'Chiese, was a Elder that your grandmother took us to when we were younger. We went to Midewin ceremonies across the Canadian prairies and in healing centers to learn from him. These are stories from Grandma: he spoke of time immemorial, and that since the beginning of time there have been trillions of galaxies that have been created and passed on. As we travel through time there are billions of star systems, beings, and galaxies in the systems, right up until our time. We were almost the last of the creation, and when we look to our known and unknow universes, we know we are not alone. Among the suns and the moons there are Star Beings. Star Beings watched the creation of our Earth and further went to Earth as it was forming. They tried to put down creation, but creation perished at first, so the Star Beings had to wait for the Earth to form more, before putting a more solid form down, but it perished too. After waiting longer, the

¹ First Nations, Metis, and Inuit Education Association of Ontario, *We Come From The Stars FNMIEAO Webinar 1* (Ontario: Youtube, 2020) < <https://youtu.be/YVHpuYkROIM>> accessed 24 April 2020.

Earth formed more, and sent another creation down through the Earth and landed. These beings were weak still, and perished. The Earth cleared, and the Star Beings with Creators permission asked to put their own creation in the being's creations, thus the first beings were half Star Clan and half human. This existence worked, and they started families with children of their own. They had a way of life that came from the stars while living on the world. Star Beings evolved and humans evolved into what are known humans today. Thus, Indigenous people today carry the genomes of Star Beings and Clan being genome in our DNA. When we do ceremony, the DNA is activated within us. As Anishinaabe people we understand the gifts of our Clans, and these gifts are in our genetics. These gifts are ordered into Clans so that we can understand each other, so when we are in families, community, and nationhood we have order. Our galaxies require order. We can use the Clan knowledge to help guide our life. These Clans are our connection to the universe.

My Sweet Baby Always Remember

Remember that we are pitiful human beings. Remember to never put anyone on a pedestal. Remember to be humble because Creation doesn't need us, but we need Creation. Never take a life, and never take your own life because it will be hard work for us to ensure you safely make it to the next world/resting place. The greatest gift you can give to your mother in this lifetime is to always choose life, always choose to live, and be a good visitor on this land while you are here. When you pick medicines and harvest food, you have to ask those spirits for consent to take their life so that your own or your families can be made better. The animals gave us their lives and power so that we could survive here on Turtle Island, as did the medicine. Do not disrespect them, they are sacred beings too, and we made a treaty with them because we are all relations living here on Earth. Always honour women, men, and all other gender variants.

Women are like water, without them there is no us, they are the beginning of love and life, so we must give thanks for women and water in ceremony. Remember you need to take care of those that need love. We all need love, but sometimes people become more vulnerable to being ignored, like our friends who are disabled or elderly. Our ancestors have been doing this since the beginning of time, taking care of our Elders.² Your mom and dad will protect your spirit even when we move on into the spirit world, we will always sit with you and protect you as an ancestor, all of our children's children until the end of time.

We Will Teach You All You Need to Know and We Will Learn Together

We will be the ones to go back to the old ones and ask questions, your grandparents are ceremonial people and knowledge keepers so they will ground all that we will come to know and pass on together. We will be the ones who go back to the old ways as a family unit. We will keep gathering ancestral Indigenous knowledge together. As children of Anishinaabe people you are corn and wild rice growers and collectors. Your people have special relations to many different lands, foods, and beings across Turtle Island. I hope that we are always surrounded by the beauty of Dene, Blackfoot, Anishinaabe, and Cree culture and designs.

Our home fire will be built on the beauty of being Indigenous, so that we are always radically intimate to the beauty within us and our nations since the beginning of time. We will teach you the laws of this land that have guided our communities and nations. We are urban Indigenous people, so we will learn about the common law (civil law), international law, and Indigenous law living together on equal footing. Our focus as a family must be Indigenous law:

² CalSWEC Online, *Minding the Indigenous Mind Dr Michael Yellowbird Keynote, Title IV E 2015 Student Day* (Online: 2018) < https://youtu.be/QHE_dg-8UzY > accessed 24 April 2020.

the sacred law, the essential laws for our communities today, and customary law to ensure that our relationships with our kin across Turtle Island are strong.³

If you want to learn more about your Clans then you have to feast, dream, go to ceremonies, and invest time into your family's knowledge base. Through the spirit world you can gain back your Clan knowledge, and bring it back to our family and communities, so that we remember what it means to have Star Being knowledge.

Appendix A: Colonization in Canada

In every space of Turtle Island Indigenous nations had Clans. Some other places in the world forgot their Clan knowledge and took a different path. Colonization tried to take over our Clan knowledge. There are parts of history (especially in Canada) that do not define who you are, and this industrial complex knowledge system of how we come to know ourselves is secondary to your ancestral knowledge as an Indigenous person walking in this world. You are worthy. You are not white, and you never have to measure up to a white idea. Your path was set with Creator and Grandmother Spider and many other Spirits, before you entered this galaxy on which you started your path. This “logic driven” institutional knowledge can be used as a tool kit to fight colonization theory and worldview, but it is not something that I want you to internalize or keep as a part of your primary ways of knowing and being in this world. This knowledge is often rife with bias, stereotypes, and ultimately you can lose something within its racist and sexist violence. You are a whole person, with a full heart, so walk with your head held high my babies. I give you permission to walk away and to survive until you thrive.

³ UVic Indigenous Law Research Unit ILRU, *Full Interview: JOHN BORROWS* (Victoria, 2015) <<https://youtu.be/sNuityiUXV0>> accessed 24 April 2020.

I caution you that the laws of land, we currently call Canada, continue to be under a colonial regime that enables colonization to remain an all indoctrinating force. It is a legal and political history that we need to change (with our allies) to reflect the truth of our humanity as Indigenous people. Colonization is brainwashing on a social, cultural, and physiological level. Be bigger than control, domination, and fear. We as human beings deserve to be healthy and happy. The Doctrine of Discovery and Nazi race theory are ideas that contaminate human beings and become infections in society. The people (settlers/colonizers) who came to our lands committed spiritual rape and genocide of Indigenous people, over our knowledge, laws, governance, and lives.⁴ The Doctrine of Discovery and Terra nullius (land that is not occupied) are theories and ideas that are diseases to effective democracy and society today. The ideas were brought forth through Christianity and the man-made law by self-proclaimed Christians didn't see Indigenous people as human beings. The Christian mission of popes, kings and queens, god (apparently), and explorers dramatically changed what they called the New World (later called North America). As far back as the 5th century Churches began to establish Christian commonwealth through international law and papal jurisdiction that under Discovery principles non-Christians did not possess the same human/sacred rights to land, sovereignty, and self determination as Christian people.⁵ Non-Christians (infidels) had to comply with European conceptions of law.⁶ By 1240 the Church could deprive pagans of their property or sovereignty if they failed to admit Christian missionaries or defied European natural law across the world.⁷ By 1455 slavery of Pagans and property theft was allowed against non-Christian owners.⁸ These

⁴ Rob Kall Bottom-up Show, *Michael Yellowbird; Neuro-Decolonization*, (Online: 2018) < <https://youtu.be/QPMQ7llxHmY>> accessed 24 April 2020.

⁵ Robert J Miller, "The Doctrine of Discovery" in Miller, Ruru, Behrendt, and Lindberg, *Discovering Indigenous Lands* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010) at 1 -25.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Ibid.

laws were transported over to Turtle Island. The British, French, and other colonies used the Doctrine of Discovery to take part in the largest land theft known to this land. There are many other things that were stolen in addition to the land. This land mass is governed currently by common law. Common law is English law and even Aboriginal law is established from European ways of thinking and knowing. We have allies, sometimes, in these systems, but these systems are still rife with colonial ideologies, so you need to remember this is not OUR law. We have our own legal systems, and your parents will show you so you can show your babies. These are man made laws, by judges who are just like us, pitiful humans. Aboriginal law has existed for less than a hundred years now, but our laws on Turtle Island have been inside us since the beginning of time.

Remember that we may have intergenerational trauma BUT we also have intergenerational resilience in our blood memory. The worse crimes committed against humanity won't break us. Residential schools didn't break us. The 60's scoop won't break us. The Doctrine of Discovery cannot break us. Why? Because we want to live. We want to be here, where Creator placed us with the Star Beings, and we want to live long healthy and beautiful lives like we are meant to. Your ancestors love you unconditionally. We love you unconditionally, forever and always, until the end of time, and into the galaxies and spaces in time we have yet to know.

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